THE PINK LEMON



Why Losing Isn't Always What It Looks Like

CHRIS MARVEL DAVIS

Before We Start

I knew pink lemonade, of course, but I had never seen a real lemon that was pink inside. There is a kind of Eureka lemon with green and cream stripes on the outside and pale pink fruit inside. As the lemon ripens, much of the green can fade until it looks like the yellow lemon we know. Cut it open, though, and the inside is still different. I liked that right away. The fruit was pink, but it was still a lemon, and it could be just as sour. I have started to think about losing the same way. The name can be right and still tell us very little about what is inside.

Somebody says, "I lost," and our minds fill in the rest. We decide they were not good enough or did not work hard enough. Then we hand out the same advice: keep your head up, work harder, don't quit, use it as fuel. But that advice has never fit every kind of loss. If you weren't good enough yet, the right move is to admit it, learn what you can, and keep working. But more effort cannot undo an injury or make another company's budget bigger. Effort also cannot change a call that was close to a coin flip. This is not a book about making lemonade out of every bad thing that happens to you.

I understand why that saying has lasted, since there are times we can turn something sour into something useful. I have done that in my own life. But I no longer believe every loss is a secret gift. I don't think pain has failed if it never turns into an inspiring story. The pink lemon reminds me to look closely before deciding what a familiar label explains. The outside does not tell a grower how well the fruit will

develop. A grower needs a closer look to know that, and a loss needs one too. We have to find out what happened before deciding what the result says about our future.

I still believe in hard work and owning your part. My father taught me to get up when something goes wrong, because nobody else can live your life for you. Along the way, I stopped believing effort explains everything, because life gave me too many examples that did not fit. My wife and I built a business that finally hit the monthly income we had chased for years. That business did not make us rich, but it gave us room to breathe, and that felt like a win.

About 45 days later, the business started coming apart. Several of our deals expired at the same time, and I had never put contracts in place for the others. I worked, worried, replayed talks in my head, and looked for the mistake I missed. Some of what I found was useful. We had trusted some people more than we should have and left parts of the business unprotected. Other parts were not going to be fixed by waking up earlier. That seems clear now, but it was not clear while I was in it.

Loss makes everything feel personal. A contract disappears, and somehow it becomes a statement about your talent. You don't make the team, and five minutes later you wonder if you were ever good. You miss the shot, and suddenly the talk in your head isn't about the shot anymore. I kept noticing how fast I jumped from what happened to what I thought it meant. Often I filled the gaps with the easiest story, which blamed me for everything or let me off the hook.

Over time, I saw five patterns. In the first, someone beat you, and in the second, the margin was too close to read. In the third, something was taken from you. In the fourth, you were playing the wrong game. In the fifth, you stopped taking part in a goal you still said you wanted. I call them The Five. They are not science, and they do not

explain every loss. They are a way to slow down and ask a question I used to skip: what actually happened?

If I don't know what happened, I don't know what I need to do. I might need to work harder, wait, grieve, change direction, or admit somebody was just better. Sometimes the answer is that I don't know yet. I used to be quicker to turn a loss into a lesson, and I'm less interested in doing that now. Some losses taught me things I am grateful to know, and some only hurt. All of them belong in an honest book about losing. I want to start with baseball. Baseball was one of the first places I learned that effort matters but does not explain every result.

CHAPTER ONE

Not One

I loved baseball before I knew much about winning or losing. I grew up in Cleveland in the 1990s, which was a good time to fall in love with the game. The Indians had players like Kenny Lofton, Albert Belle, and Omar Vizquel. A city that had waited years for a championship could talk itself into believing this was finally the team. They made the World Series twice that decade and lost both times. As a kid, I couldn't explain why being so close made it hurt more.

I watched games, played pickup ball with friends, and hit in batting cages. On library trips with my dad, I grabbed baseball books, and *Nolan Ryan's Pitcher's Bible* is one I remember. I wanted to know why one person could throw harder and another could hit better, and what practice actually changed. Mostly I wanted to know how people got good. My dad had a simple answer for what to do when you weren't good enough yet. You kept going, and you didn't sit around feeling sorry for yourself. You figured out what to do and tried again. Nobody was going to climb inside your life and fix it for you. I still believe that, because some losses really are that simple.

You were not ready, or someone worked harder, or someone had a skill you did not. Maybe you got distracted, let fear take over, or assumed that wanting something would be enough. If that is what happened, I would rather know. I don't want somebody to protect my feelings with a story that isn't true. Talking about failure should

not excuse us from looking honestly at our part. Baseball taught me some of that, but it also taught me that simple losses weren't the whole story. When I tried out for my high school team in eleventh grade, I felt ready. It was at least the kind of ready I understood then.

Then I got around other kids who wanted the same spot. Some had better gear, and some had travel teams, coaches, and practice that pickup games couldn't fully replace. That didn't mean they didn't work, because they did, and it also didn't mean I had done nothing. We had reached the same tryout by different roads. That may have been the first time I saw how many people can care deeply about the same chance. The roster had only so many places, and wanting a spot would not make my preparation equal to theirs.

Business works the same way, because many people want the same customer. Wanting something badly can feel special when you are alone with that wish. Then you walk into a room full of people who want it just as badly. You realize that wanting it is only the starting point, and preparation, access, and the small details begin to matter.

I made the team, and that matters, because for years I judged the story by how it ended. The ending disappointed me, so I treated the whole experience as a disappointment. Then I got injured, and I never got to see what my full potential in baseball might have been. That's the story, and I don't need to make it bigger than it was. But I was disappointed. Baseball had filled so much of my imagination that I had to find new things to dream about. I grieved it, and then I moved on.

What I didn't understand yet was why this loss felt different. If another kid struck me out, that told me something. He might have had a better pitch, or my timing might have been off. An injury didn't tell me anything like that. I had grown up learning that losing was evidence. You lose, so you practice more and figure out what the

winner did that you didn't. The injury ended the season without answering those questions. That was hard to fit into the rules I had learned. I had done enough to make the team, and I still didn't get the season I pictured. For a while, I acted like the injury meant making the team had never counted.

As I've gotten older, I've noticed how fast we reach for an explanation. We say the winner worked harder and the loser didn't want it enough. That's right some of the time. Often, though, we're reading the ending backward and inventing a story that makes the result look certain. After someone succeeds, a morning routine or a book on the shelf becomes the reason. We say that even when we don't know how much it mattered. We rarely look at the people who did the same things and still lost.

I did not understand any of that in eleventh grade. All I knew was that baseball was becoming something I used to do. Years later, I was teaching, coaching, building businesses, and raising sons. I was also losing things that cost a lot more than a baseball season. I kept coming back to one question: what does a loss actually prove? Some losses prove a lot, and others prove almost nothing. That difference matters because of what we tend to do next. When people care about you, they want to make your pain useful fast. They say, "Everything happens for a reason," or "God has something better," or "Keep your head up." I get it, and I have said those things too.

I am a Christian, and I believe God can use things I would never have chosen. I also don't think my faith asks me to pretend I know why every painful thing happened. Some losses sent me in a new direction, and I can see that now because enough time has passed. But I don't think every bad thing is fertilizer and we just keep digging until we find the flower. Sometimes the only honest sentence is, *I hate that this happened.* I'm more okay with that now.

What worries me more is when we skip understanding the loss and jump straight to fixing ourselves. If somebody beat you because they were better, getting better makes sense. If the loss came down to something close to random, that needs a different talk. If something was taken from you, hunting for your own failure can turn into punishment. If you've been winning the wrong game, working harder can take you further from the life you want. If you walked away because staying cost too much, calling yourself a quitter may get the whole thing wrong.

Those are different losses, and I didn't know that when I was seventeen. I knew one thing: get back up. I'm grateful my father taught me that, and it carried me through hard seasons. Learning when to keep moving, and where to aim that effort, took me much longer.

KEEP READING

That was one kind of loss. There are five.

The rest of *The Pink Lemon* sorts them out:

1. Somebody beat you
2. The margin was almost random
3. Something was taken
4. You were playing the wrong game
5. You walked out

Each one asks for a different response.

OUT NOV 30, 2026 · PAPERBACK + KINDLE

Find it at chrismarvelspeaks.com/pinklemon
Speaking, bulk orders and interviews: ChrisMarvelSpeaks.com

© 2026 Chris Marvel Davis. Free to share in full.